

TSA ICR Items 12-15

Consistency, Analytical Controls, and Opportunities for Economic Analysis

Economic Analysis Branch leadership brief | September 9, 2026

Executive summary

TSA's published burden and cost methods show substantial coherence where activities are genuinely comparable. The more direct observed control risk is reconciliation within individual published Supporting Statements, where calculations, tables, periods, scope definitions, and narrative can diverge. [1]

A review of 90 recent Transportation Security Administration (TSA) Information Collection Request (ICR) packages across 48 assigned control histories found recurring, coherent analytical components and observable explanations for several differences. Six task/method questions remain unresolved from published evidence. These results support preserving useful analytical methods while strengthening the controls connecting their inputs and outputs.

The distinction matters for the Economic Analysis Branch (EAB). **Method governance** concerns whether an analytical choice fits the activity and is applied coherently under comparable conditions. **Model-to-output governance** concerns whether sources, assumptions, calculations, tables, footnotes, summaries, and narrative remain synchronized. The completed review provides a more direct basis for strengthening the second category than for imposing common numeric assumptions across unlike activities.

The pipeline plan-review example makes the distinction concrete. Its role-hour structure is coherent, yet displayed hours and rates reproduce approximately **\$347,824**, against a published **\$290,825.84**. The calculated product is not an official corrected amount. A coherent method can still require stronger control over its published cost representation. [4]

Recommended decision: If EAB leadership wants to proceed, test a common, source-bound quantitative model and deterministic quality-assurance controls on a small number of upcoming ICR renewals or revisions. Generate output tables and draft Items 12-15 narrative from one reviewed quantitative source of truth, with human analytical review before publication.

The pilot would build on existing strengths, preserve justified differentiation, and make reconstruction and change accounting easier to review. Potential operational benefits remain unmeasured; this brief makes no claim of quantified savings or staffing reductions.

This analysis evaluates observable published estimation practices and analytical controls. It identifies practical opportunities for stronger consistency, reconstruction, and reuse; it does not evaluate individual analysts or infer undocumented internal causes.

What was examined

Supporting Statement A Items 12-15 cover respondent burden and labor valuation, nonlabor costs, Federal costs, and changes from the applicable baseline. The review examined recent package versions received from September 9, 2021, through September 9, 2026. [2]

Evidence coverage	Count	Interpretation
Recent TSA ICR packages	90	Includes historical versions, proposals, and pending submissions
Assigned control histories	48	Histories can contain multiple package versions
Principal activity representations	468	Structured descriptions of source-defined tasks; representations can overlap
Reviewed assumption observations	162	Includes repeated versions and formula-header coefficients
Quantitative checks	341	Heterogeneous checks across 40 versions; not complete model validation

Principal-task normalization does not imply full validation of every underlying model. Nor does it make every activity comparable. The review aligned actors, task boundaries, population or event definitions, units, periods, and lifecycle stages before interpreting numerical agreement or difference.

The evidence supports case-based conclusions. The 90 packages are not 90 independent, currently approved collections; the checks and observations are neither independent nor evenly distributed. Their counts cannot establish a portfolio error rate.

Two separate registers, two different questions

This register includes cross-ICR comparisons, lineage comparisons, and selected within-package component comparisons. It is not 32 independent cross-program observations.

Task/method adjudications	Count	Within-ICR findings	Count
Consistent	15	Potentially inconsistent	7
Different but explained	8	Unresolved	1
Potentially inconsistent	0	Total	8
Not comparable	3		
Unresolved	6		
Total	32		

These are adjudicated review cases, not a statistically representative error rate. **The registers are analytically different and should not be combined into a portfolio inconsistency rate.** [3]

Preserve coherent methods and explained differences

The comparative evidence supports useful recurring structures. Carrier and cargo security-program requests retain a one-hour documentation coefficient. Surface security-training amendments retain an eight-hour coefficient, while training record entry retains one minute per record. Cybersecurity plan review retains eight manager hours plus 24 analyst hours per plan. Agreement applies to the specified component and its boundaries. [3]

These observations show coherence and continuity. They do not independently establish how long the work actually takes or validate every coefficient for future use. A recurring value should retain its source, scope, and review status when carried forward.

Several observed differences have explanations in the work itself. Initial applications and incremental resubmissions do not necessarily contain the same tasks. Security-threat triage differs from contractor response handling. A pathway that includes fingerprinting and travel differs from one that avoids those steps. Source vintage, employee universe, online migration, and payer identity can also explain variation. Explained differences should remain explained; they are not a residual list of defects.

Six questions for targeted clarification

Published evidence alone could not fully resolve the following task/method questions. They warrant analyst and program context, source clarification, or underlying-model review where available. They are not errors. [3]

Question	Evidence needed
Airport and carrier-requested amendment preparation	Separate preparation, submission, and implementation for aligned amendment types
Coordinator contact updates	Align person contacts, coordinator/alternate bundles, and operator events
Medical applicant travel	Clarify one-way versus round-trip measures and applicant-population fit
Online credential renewals	Align form content, conditional biometrics, and timing evidence
Federal amendment review	Separate active work by role and amendment type; clarify pooled scope
Coordinator turnover	Align person-stock and operator-event denominators and establish annual calibration

An absence of published explanation does not prove an absence of internal rationale. The appropriate response is to request the missing context, not to infer an efficiency ranking or replace the coefficient automatically.

EAB opportunity: standardize the information needed to judge applicability before standardizing numeric task times or proxy choices.

The principal case: coherent staffing, unreconciled output

The reviewed pipeline cybersecurity package was active and approved with change at the September 9, 2026 snapshot. Its Federal plan-review paragraph displays 100 reviews, eight manager hours per plan at \$122.27, and 24 analyst hours per plan at \$104.17. [4]

Coherent method structure	Published cost representation
8 manager hours + 24 analyst hours per plan	Displayed inputs reproduce \$347,824
Role-hour components agree in the comparative review	Published value: \$290,825.84
Preserve role-based estimation and task boundaries	Require the cost product to reconcile with workload, rates, and period

Displayed-input reconstruction

$100 \times [(8 \times \$122.27) + (24 \times \$104.17)] = \textbf{\$347,824}$

The underlying role-hour structure can be coherent while the published cost product still fails to reproduce from the displayed inputs. Wage rounding across the displayed review hours does not reconcile the difference.

The calculated amount is not an official correction or an estimate of actual spending. The reviewed public evidence does not establish which alternative inputs or recurrence convention, if any, should govern the official estimate.

The prior version carries the same total with lower wages and one-time review wording. That continuity does not establish why the later representation differs from its displayed inputs. Published discrepancies do not establish how or why they arose.

What the example supports

A deterministic reconciliation control would multiply the declared workload by role-specific hours and rates, preserve the applicable period, and compare the result with every downstream cost representation. A discrepancy would remain visible until an analyst documents its resolution or disposition.

The control would not decide whether the staffing assumption is behaviorally correct. That remains an analytical question. It would ensure that the published output follows the reviewed model.

Institutional implication: EAB can retain the useful role-based structure while requiring the calculation, table, footnote, and narrative to use the same reviewed inputs and result.

Counterevidence and a positive reconciliation example

The completed report tested explanations that narrow apparent discrepancies. Its conclusions depend on preserving that counterevidence. [5]

- **Hazardous Materials Endorsement (HME):** the online-pathway overlap issue concerns a pending package. Earlier HME and Transportation Worker Identification Credential (TWIC) pathway partitions reconcile. The pending issue does not establish a collection-wide failure or approved workload.
- **Law enforcement officer (LEO) collection:** the annual narrative agrees with its annual product, although one annual table cell approximates three years. The concern is the relationship between the cell, label, and narrative, not a conclusion that all annual calculations fail.
- **PreCheck:** named correction and survey activities explain the gap between all-activity and valued hours within rounding. The retained question is valuation scope, not arithmetic error. It is the single unresolved within-ICR finding.
- **Explained variation:** differences attributable to task scope, pathway, source, or payer remain explained. Explanation does not certify every proxy, but it prevents unlike work from being treated as contradictory evidence.

TWIC: what a traceable Item 15 bridge looks like

Reconciliation step	Annualized burden hours
Verified prior baseline	430,317
Net of six displayed component changes	+80,154
New annualized burden	510,471
Residual	0

The registered bridge explicitly connects the predecessor baseline, component changes, and new total. It supplies a positive example of traceable change accounting. [6]

This is a verified component bridge, not causal attribution of every underlying driver. It does not isolate the contributions of population, task time, pathway shares, or interactions within each component. Other Item 15 baselines have not been equivalently validated.

EAB could use this structure in a pilot: retain baseline identity, record each component change, and require prior plus changes to equal new. If a causal explanation is needed, document a separate decomposition with its assumptions and treatment of interactions.

The combined lesson is bounded: preserve successful reconciliations, identify precisely which relationship remains unresolved, and avoid expanding a case finding beyond its evidence.

Why this matters to EAB

An ICR estimate can later inform a renewal, a program analysis, or economic and regulatory work. Reuse requires more than a published total. A reviewer needs to identify the activity, population, period, wage treatment, source, formula, and applicable baseline. [7]

A common structure could make prior analysis easier to reconstruct and adapt. It could support faster renewals, clearer assumption review, fewer transcription and reconciliation defects, and less duplicate maintenance of calculations, tables, footnotes, and prose. These are prospective benefits to test, not measured outcomes.

Direction	EAB action	Evidence of completion
KEEP	Preserve coherent activity decomposition, component estimation, source-backed wage and workload inputs, legitimate differentiation, and analyst judgment	Reused components retain their source, task boundary, and applicability
STANDARDIZE	Adopt common activity archetypes, source identity fields, units, periods, population/event definitions, assumption records, wage transformations, baseline ledgers, and formula lineage	A reviewer can determine whether an input applies without reconstructing its meaning from scattered prose
CONTROL - first priority	Make arithmetic, subtotals, population partitions, pathway shares, units, periods, wage transformations, Federal workload, Item 15 bridges, and table/narrative reconciliation deterministic	Reproducible checks show inputs, results, tolerance, and disposition; outputs trace to one reviewed model
INVESTIGATE	Resolve the six method questions and other unclear scope or valuation rules with analyst/program context	Missing evidence and decisions are recorded; unresolved questions remain distinct from errors

Standardizing structures preserves room for justified case-specific coefficients. A common source field does not require a common proxy; a common time unit does not require identical task duration.

Controls should distinguish arithmetic failures from missing evidence and review warnings. Population partitions require a declared relationship: alternative pathways should reconcile to their parent cohort, while additive activities need their own trigger and frequency. Automation can test that relationship after analysts specify it.

EAB can build on the coherent practices already observed. The immediate opportunity is a more reviewable analytical record and synchronized outputs, with explicit responsibility for assumptions and interpretation.

One reviewed quantitative source of truth

Each downstream numerical representation should derive from one reviewed quantitative result, with its sources, assumptions, formula, period, and version identifiable. This is a proposed architecture, not a description of current internal procedures. [7]

Stage	What it carries forward
Sources	Document identity, source locator, reference period, and original value
↓ Structured inputs	Units, population/event identity, and evidence status
↓ Assumptions	Rationale, applicability, proxy choices, and justified exceptions
↓ Calculations	Formula lineage, full precision, and scenario identity
↓ Validation	Arithmetic, scope, period, partition, wage, and baseline checks
↓ Output tables	Values and labels obtained from validated results
↓ Items 12-15 narrative	Draft numerical statements and references tied to the same results

Human analytical review remains present throughout: establish scope and assumptions before calculation; resolve validation issues; review interpretation and approve the final statement before publication. A material change returns to the relevant input or assumption and is recalculated and rechecked.

A wage update should flow to the role-cost calculation, table, and draft narrative. An annual result should retain its annual label. A valuation exclusion should remain visible alongside the all-activity total. An Item 15 change should preserve its baseline and ledger.

The architecture addresses the observed model-to-output risk by reducing independent representations of the same quantitative result. It does not require all source documents to reside in one file or all ICRs to use one methodology.

Human review determines whether an occupation is an appropriate wage proxy, whether a task time fits the obligation, whether an event statistic fits the modeled period, and whether a burden exclusion is justified. Deterministic checks establish whether the declared relationships reproduce; they cannot supply missing analytical rationale.

Generated narrative should express reviewed model content. It should not invent an explanation for an unresolved input. Final review should recheck numbers and scope after editorial changes.

A bounded pilot and next decision

If EAB leadership wants to proceed, test the approach on a small number of upcoming ICR renewals or revisions using a common source-bound quantitative model and deterministic quality-assurance controls. The recommendation does not require a procurement request or a broad transformation program. [8]

Select cases that exercise a role-based Federal-cost calculation, a branching respondent model, and an Item 15 renewal bridge. These structures address different observed risks; they need not require three separate collections.

Minimum pilot outputs

1. A source/provenance registry and structured assumptions with explicit applicability rules.
2. Formula-preserving calculations, declared population relationships, and a baseline/change ledger.
3. Automated reconciliation checks with visible tolerances and documented issue dispositions.
4. Generated tables and draft Items 12-15 narrative tied to reviewed quantitative results.
5. Human analytical and publication review, with a second analyst reconstructing material outputs.

Acceptance questions for leadership

Can a second analyst trace each material number to its source and formula? Can the reviewer explain each pathway relationship and reproduce each baseline bridge? Do a supported input change and the resulting recalculation reach every affected table and numerical statement? Are unresolved assumptions visible and assigned a disposition before publication?

Test both positive and negative cases. The controls should detect a displayed-input cost mismatch while accepting a coherent pathway partition and a valid component bridge. A justified difference must remain acceptable rather than being forced into numerical uniformity.

Proposed roles: EAB defines the model and checks; program partners clarify assumptions; Paperwork Reduction Act reviewers review the statement. Leadership confirms assignments.

After the pilot, assess reconstruction quality, unresolved review issues, and practical maintenance demands before deciding whether to expand reusable structures. Operational performance and resource requirements have not been measured by this study.

Source note

This brief synthesizes Consistency and Defensibility of Burden and Cost Estimation Across TSA Information Collections, September 9, 2026, the 55-page technical report. That report remains the evidentiary record, including source references, full adjudications, and limitations.

[1] Executive summary; sections 10 and 14.

[2] Sections 1-3 and 13.

[3] Sections 4-6; complete comparison register and unresolved-comparison table.

[4] Section 7.9, "Pipeline cybersecurity: coherent staffing, unreconciled cost."

[5] Section 7, including HME, LEO, and PreCheck case discussions.

[6] Section 7.10, "Item 15: a verified bridge and a bounded conclusion."

[7] Sections 8, 10, and 11.

[8] Section 12, especially implementation sequencing in section 12.5.